Mulatto Poetry Program

By Langston Hughes and Zora Howard

Cross by Langston Hughes

My old man's a white old man

And my old mother's black.

If ever I cursed my white old man

I take my curses back.

If ever I cursed my black old mother

And wished she were in hell,

I'm sorry for that evil wish

And now I wish her well

My old man died in a fine big house.

My ma died in a shack

I wonder where I'm going to die,

Being neither white nor black.

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INTRODUCTION

That first poem was Cross by Langston Hughes . . . and it makes me think about the difficulty of growing up as a part of two different cultures.

I often hear people say things like, "It doesn't matter what you look like on the outside; it's what's inside that counts," or "Nobody's really different; we are all the same," Really?

Let's keep it real, we are not all the same, and you can sugar-coat it if you'd like to, but at the end of the day, each one of us has a unique story to tell and personal struggle that is all our own. Mulatto by Langston Hughes tells of his personal struggle to fit in.

Mulatto by Langston Hughes

I am your son, white man!

Georgia dusk

And the turpentine woods.

One of the pillars of the temple fell.

You are my son!

Like Hell!

The moon over the turpentine woods.

The Southern night

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Full of stars,
Great big yellow stars.
What's a body but a toy?
Juicy bodies
Of nigger wenches
Blue black
Against black fences.
O, you little bastard boy,
What's a body but a toy?
The scent of pine wood stings the soft night air.
What's the body of your mother?
Silver moonlight everywhere.
What's the body of your mother?
Sharp pine scent in the evening air.
A nigger night,
A nigger joy,
A little yellow
Bastard boy. Naw, you ain't my brother.
Niggers ain't my brother.
Not ever.
Niggers ain't my brother.

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The Southern night is full of stars,
Great big yellow stars.
O, sweet as earth,
Dusk dark bodies
Give sweet birth
To little yellow bastard boys.
Git on back there in the night,
You ain't white
The bright stars scatter everywhere.
Pine wood scent in the evening air.
A nigger night,
A nigger joy. I am your son, white man!
A little yellow
Bastard boy.

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TRANSITION

Take two or more cultural identities and mix them together, then slap a few labels and stereotypes onto them, dice 'em up and then, just for fun, put them all back together again into whatever one box you see fit that day based on, say . . . hair texture, skin tone, eye or nose shape, and lip fullness, et voila! You've got a mixed-race person. And for 13 year old Zora Howard, Bi-racial Hair is the worst!

Biracial Hair by Zora Howard

I have bi-racial hair

Pantene Pro-V waves on the top

Easy to style, comb, rock-

Until-I encounter my naps,

I'm not talking about those-cute detangle with the spray naps.

I'm talking about those, slave naps, like,

No comb, brush, or man can handle the kind of naps I got- like,

No way you are touching my hair-naps like

Back 10 feet up, or we can dance naps

Those naps like-

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D***!

I have bi-racial hair,

Those smooth and silk rafts hanging all through my mane,

Until you get to the back, and encounter the jungle, in which you can find Tarzan and Jane.

In the front you forget and relax in the pleasure,

Until you get to the back and remember pain

Baby hair slicked back with that good 4 dollar pomade,

That goes with roots and tangles,

Soaked with that same olive oil; mixed with that spaghetti sauce mom made.

I have bi-racial hair,

Combs run freely through my fine breezy, just to the part, the most you can make,

Until it gets to the back and

Breaks.

I have bi-racial hair

Like-

The only thing my mother could put it in was 2 big braids,

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And sometimes that was to much,
So she left half undone.
I was in the mirror, I was in the mirror,
Convincing myself I looked just like a dark-skinned Alicia Keys
I have bi-racial hair,
because I have bi-racial blood.
I'm not talking about that-cute they met then fell in love, blood
I'm talking about that- slaved raped six times by the master,
Birthing 6 mixed babies, later hung blood
I'm talking about that cross burning in the mud, blood
And you call me a mud blood,
Slit my wrist,
my blood does not excrete in black and white.
I dream in verse and in red
Like what drained from Emmett Tills' lips when he was killed for breaking down color lines
Bi-racial who succumbs to the abuse from her peers in her middle school,

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Those whose who constantly called me an Oreo
Well she's not white, it's more like Reese's cookie, mixed breed or a mulatto
That's what it is a reverse mulatto
I AM NOT A F****** COOKIE OR A B****!
My roots are deep too
my bi-racial roots are not blind
or more than cotton soft
cause my blood were in the sun, picking cotton too
a thousand times desecrated for my race
a thousand time desecrated from my history y'all never get
let textbooks be your truth
and sprinkle the ashes of your history into streams
I dream for a time and place where
maybe y'all all accept me
maybe we need to wake up again and remember a morning of you
like something new
baby I'll be green cause my people drove there
you people drove me there

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with my tender heart

tender head

and my bi-racial hair

SOURCE INFORMATION

Cross by Langston Hughes and Mulatto by Langston Hughes

Book: The Collected Poems of Langston Hughes
ISBN: 978-1439571736
Publisher: Vintage Classics
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2008

Biracial Hair by Zora Howard

Book: Clutch
ISBN: 978-0983121909
Publisher: Penmanship Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2011

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